

Comprehensive Early Warning Signs of War and Scenario Analysis

Introduction

Armed conflicts have surged to their highest levels since World War II, straining the global peace and security architecture ¹. In 2024 there were over 60 active conflicts worldwide – **74% more** than the early 2000s ². The United Nations warns that modern wars are becoming “less responsive to traditional forms of resolution,” making preventive action ever more critical ³. In this context, **early warning of war** is indispensable. Early warning is generally defined as **alerting authorities to the threat of new or renewed conflict sufficiently in advance** that preventive measures can be attempted ⁴. This capability is a cornerstone of conflict prevention: by detecting the warning signs of war early, leaders and institutions have a chance – however slim – to defuse crises before they escalate into full-blown violence ⁵ ⁶. History shows that once a war erupts, the costs in lives and resources are staggering, so **timely foresight** is literally an exercise in saving lives and preserving peace. Yet, as we will examine, achieving effective early warning and response remains an enormous challenge, requiring neutral analysis, verified evidence, and the political will to act on warnings. This report provides a **comprehensive view of early warning signs** of war and explores multiple scenarios of conflict escalation or prevention. All findings are presented with a neutral, evidence-based approach, as befits a UN-style assessment under rigorous scrutiny.

Key Early Warning Signs of War

Wars do not erupt in a vacuum – they are usually preceded by a **pattern of indicators** and pressures that can be observed. Analysts distinguish between **structural factors**, **escalating triggers**, and **proximate flashpoints** that together signal a rising risk of conflict ⁷ ⁸. Below we outline the major early warning signs of war, from deep-rooted causes to immediate precursors, drawing on historical and contemporary examples:

- **Long-Term Structural Tensions:** These are the “logs” in the fire of conflict ⁷ – underlying issues that create a combustible environment. Examples include **long-standing grievances**, **territorial disputes**, or **severe socio-economic inequalities** between groups. In international conflicts, unresolved claims over land or resources, rivalry in armaments, or the persecution of minorities can all be structural warning signs ⁹ ¹⁰. Such conditions do not cause war on their own, but they provide the fuel. For instance, deep ethnic and political grievances laid the groundwork for violence in the Balkans in the 1990s, and **territorial disagreements** have persisted as latent flashpoints between many states (e.g. India-Pakistan over Kashmir). When these conditions exist, conflict analysts monitor them as **latent risk factors**.
- **Political and Economic Instability:** Sudden changes or crises in a state’s governance or economy are akin to “kindling” that **accelerates the fire** ¹¹. Warning signs in this category include **abrupt regime change**, **contested elections**, or **constitutional crises**, which can spark power struggles ¹². **Political oppression** – such as crackdowns on opposition or curtailment of rights – is another red flag that tensions are reaching a boiling point ¹¹. Economic distress often intertwines with political instability: **spiking inflation**, **unemployment**, or **sharp**

economic downturns create public anger and desperation ¹². Analysts note that rising unemployment or surging prices are signals of future turmoil, undermining public wellbeing and trust in government ¹². These conditions can manifest in **mass protests, strikes, or civil disobedience**, indicating a society's disillusionment and raising the risk of violent unrest ¹³. In sum, when a country experiences governance crises or economic freefall, **early warning systems treat it as a serious alert** for potential conflict.

- **Social Divisions and Mobilization: Signs of growing social unrest** or polarization are critical early warnings, especially for internal conflicts. This may include **large-scale protests, inter-ethnic or inter-religious tensions, hate speech trends, or militia mobilization** among civilian groups. For example, peaceful protest movements that persist or face repression can be precursors to revolt or civil war if grievances are not addressed ¹⁴. **Rising sectarian rhetoric** or propaganda campaigns that dehumanize groups are often ominous signals – tragically, history shows such hate indicators preceded genocides and ethnic conflicts (e.g. radio hate speech before the Rwandan genocide). Analysts also watch for **political militias or armed factions forming**, as their activities (recruitment, arms trafficking, paramilitary training) suggest preparation for violence. In short, the **“temperature” of societal discord** – whether through demonstrations, strikes, or communal clashes – is a thermometer for how close a nation might be to the brink of conflict.
- **Military Buildup and Hard Security Indicators:** Perhaps the most vivid warning signs of impending war are **military in origin** – the concrete moves that indicate a state is preparing for armed confrontation. These include **unusual troop mobilizations, large-scale military exercises near borders, abrupt deployments of forces** to forward positions, or calling up reservists ¹⁵. For example, **major movements of troops and heavy weaponry** toward a frontier are a classic red flag; satellite imagery and intelligence reports tracked exactly this kind of buildup on Ukraine's borders in late 2021 before war erupted in 2022 ¹⁶ ¹⁷. An increase in **defense spending or arms imports** beyond routine levels can signal that a country is gearing up its war-fighting capacity ¹⁸. Military **alert status changes** (like putting forces on high alert) are another sign of war readiness. Even **logistical preparations** can be telling: for instance, U.S. intelligence observed Russia moving **medical blood supplies to the front lines** in January 2022, a subtle but critical indicator that an invasion was likely since it showed readiness to treat battlefield casualties ¹⁹ ²⁰. All these military indicators – from deployments to warstock logistics – combine to create a **composite perception of threat** ¹⁵. If multiple such signals are detected (troop movements plus heightened rhetoric and logistics), analysts assess that the **probability of conflict is escalating sharply**.
- **Trigger Events (“the Match”):** Finally, wars often have proximate trigger events – the single spark that ignites the conflict, analogous to a lit match hitting fuel ⁸. These **triggers** might be deliberate or accidental incidents that push tensions over the edge. Examples include **political assassinations, terrorist attacks, border skirmishes, coup d'état attempts, or declarations of independence/secession**. Even symbolic acts can trigger violence if they enflame passions – for instance, a high-profile visit to a contested holy site in Jerusalem in 2000 (by Ariel Sharon) is cited as a trigger that ignited the Second Intifada ²¹. In interstate contexts, a **sudden military clash** or false-flag operation at the border could provide the pretext for war. Analysts remain vigilant for any such incident during times of crisis, as a trigger event can collapse the remaining restraint and lead directly to armed hostilities. **Early warning systems attempt to forecast not just the structural risk of war, but also these potential trigger moments**, though predicting the exact trigger is often the hardest part. As one conflict scholar noted, observers may “see the logs and kindling” of conflict for a long time but have “no idea when the match will strike” ²².

This unpredictability of timing means even well-warned crises can still surprise us if the triggering event comes suddenly or is orchestrated in secret.

In practice, **effective early warning analysis looks at all these layers together**. Structural risk factors (the “conflict logs”) tell us where underlying dangers exist; accelerating factors (“kindling”) show tensions rising; and specific triggers (“matches”) indicate conflict could erupt imminently ⁷ ⁸ . By tracking a variety of indicators – economic trends, political events, social media sentiment, military intelligence, etc. – analysts build an integrated picture of conflict risk. For example, a country with longstanding ethnic grievances (structural) experiencing mass protests after a disputed election (escalating factor) and a recent string of armed clashes (potential triggers) would rank extremely high on war risk. In contrast, a country might have serious underlying disputes but no immediate triggers, suggesting conflict is possible but not yet inevitable ²³ .

It is important to note that **no single indicator guarantees war**; rather, it’s the **overall pattern and accumulation** of warning signs that matters ²⁴ ²⁵ . Analysts use frameworks like the above to weigh the evidence. They also compare against historical cases (for instance, noting that prior to many past wars there were similar patterns of mobilization and inflammatory rhetoric). Modern technology has greatly enhanced this monitoring: **artificial intelligence systems now scan news, social media, and satellite imagery in real time to detect early warning signals** that humans might miss ²⁶ ²⁷ . AI can quantify subtle changes – for example, detecting a **shift in the tone of diplomatic statements or unusual troop deployments over time** – that may indicate preparation for conflict ²⁸ . Such tools augment human analysts by sifting through massive data for weak signals of crisis. Ultimately, however, human judgment is needed to interpret the signs and issue warnings. And as we discuss next, issuing a warning is only half the battle – the warning must also be **heeded**.

Early Warning Systems and Challenges (Bridging the “Warning-Response” Gap)

Recognizing warning signs is part of a broader process that includes **analysis, warning communication, and response** ²⁹ ³⁰ . The international community has invested in formal **Conflict Early Warning Systems (EWS)** to systematize this process. For example, the **African Union’s Continental Early Warning System (CEWS)** and the regional CEWARN mechanism were pioneers in establishing monitoring hubs to track conflict indicators across Africa ³¹ ³² . Globally, initiatives like the U.S. government’s **Integrated Crisis Early Warning System (ICEWS)**, the **Violence Early-Warning System (VIEWS)** project, and NGOs like **ACLED** (Armed Conflict Location & Event Data) collect data on conflicts and use predictive modeling to foresee escalating violence ³³ . These systems have evolved over decades from simple forecasting models into **multi-layered platforms using Big Data and AI** ³¹ . Today’s cutting-edge EWS employ machine learning to analyze patterns in everything from economic reports to Twitter feeds, aiming to catch crises in the making ²⁶ ²⁷ . For instance, an AI-driven system might flag a country where social media discourse has turned sharply hostile or where satellite images show new troop encampments, prompting analysts to investigate further ²⁸ . This “fifth generation” of early warning tools – integrating **deep learning and high-resolution data** – is delivering more timely, granular insights than ever before ³¹ ³⁴ .

However, an early warning is only as good as the response it elicits. A major challenge highlighted by experts is the persistent “**warning-response gap**” ³⁵ . In practice, many well-founded warnings of

conflict **fail to trigger timely preventive action** by decision-makers. There are several reasons for this failure path from warning to response ³⁶ ³⁷ :

- **Limited Political Will:** Governments and international bodies often hesitate to act on warnings due to **political calculations or competing priorities**. They may be unconvinced of the urgency, or reluctant to intervene in another nation's affairs absent undeniable evidence. As a 2025 study noted, early warnings "often fail to catalyze timely political action" because leaders find it easier to ignore abstract risks until a crisis erupts ³⁵ . It can be politically safer to do nothing than to mobilize resources based on a prediction that might not materialize – a classic case of **risk aversion**.
- **Institutional Inertia and Siloes:** Bureaucratic hurdles and unclear mandates can slow down response. Large institutions (whether the UN, regional bodies, or national agencies) may have **ambiguous protocols about who should act on a warning and how** ³⁷ ³⁸ . Early warning reports can get lost amid other diplomatic and development agendas. Different departments might assume someone else will handle it. This inertia means by the time consensus is reached or **"triggers for response"** are met, the conflict may already be breaking out ³⁸ ³⁹ .
- **Demand for Certainty:** Decision-makers often ask for more data, more confirmation, and **greater certainty before taking preventive steps** ³⁷ ³⁹ . Unlike a late humanitarian response (when violence is visible), acting early means **acting on forecasts** – and if those forecasts are perceived as uncertain, leaders balk. They may say, "How do we know this will really happen?" or hope that maybe the worst can be avoided without costly intervention. This desire for high confidence delays action until warnings become "late warnings" (when conflict is imminent or underway) ⁴⁰ ⁴¹ .
- **Resource and Capacity Gaps:** Even if there is willingness, there may not be an **adequate mechanism to respond quickly**. Effective prevention could require mediators on the ground, peacekeeping forces, or targeted economic aid – tools that take time to mobilize. Many conflict hotspots are in regions where international actors have **limited infrastructure or personnel ready to deploy** ³⁹ . As one analysis observed, in places where data shows conflict is about to erupt, often "operational capacities to respond quickly are simply not in place" ³⁹ ⁴² . This logistical lag is a critical failure path: warnings come, but no one is able to surge in fast enough to stabilize the situation.
- **Cognitive and Perceptual Biases:** Leaders and even analysts are human – they can **downplay warning signs due to optimism or disbelief**. A common pattern is the "it won't really happen" mindset. For example, on the eve of Russia's 2022 invasion of Ukraine, **many officials in Europe, and even some experts, remained convinced an invasion was unlikely**, despite U.S. intelligence warnings ⁴³ ⁴⁴ . EU foreign policy chief Josep Borrell later admitted, "We did not believe that the war was going to happen," even as Russian forces amassed, calling it a *"psychological barrier"* that most assumed the military buildup was just a bluff ⁴⁵ ⁴⁶ . This kind of **confirmation bias** – interpreting events in line with wishful thinking or past experience (e.g. "major war in Europe is unthinkable") – can lead to paralysis. Only when the bombs start falling does the reality set in, by which time the window for prevention has closed ¹⁷ ⁴⁷ . Overcoming this bias requires strong imagination and political courage to act on warnings of even "self-evidently stupid" actions, as one strategist remarked about underestimating Putin's intent ⁴⁴ .

These factors contribute to early warnings being ignored or responded to too slowly, allowing conflicts to ignite. The **UN's own record** sadly shows many missed opportunities: from the Korean War in 1950 to the Rwandan genocide in 1994, there were ample warning signs that went unheeded ⁴⁸ ⁴⁹ . One

striking example: **UN observers in 1990 saw Iraq massing forces and logistics, yet the UN was caught unaware by the invasion of Kuwait**, which in hindsight had “substantial preparations” visible beforehand ⁵⁰. Such failures are studied intensely to improve early warning systems. The **gap between information and action** – knowing and doing – remains the Achilles’ heel of conflict prevention ³⁵ ⁴¹. Bridging this gap will require not only better data (which we are getting) but better governance: clear protocols for response, funding for rapid preventive deployments, and international consensus that acting early is better than reacting late ³⁷ ³⁹. Encouragingly, there is growing recognition of this need. Major policy frameworks (e.g. the UN’s *New Agenda for Peace* and the World Bank’s prevention strategies) now call for strengthening “**national prevention strategies**” and linking warning to early action ⁵¹ ⁵². In essence, the world is trying to ensure that when the next warning comes, it does not fall on deaf ears. As we look to the future of a specific war scenario, we must incorporate these lessons: multiple outcomes are possible, and proactive response at the first warning sign can drastically alter the course of events.

Multiple Scenarios of War: Escalation and Containment Paths

Because war dynamics are complex and uncertain, analysts use **scenario analysis** to envision different ways a conflict might unfold. Scenario planning is a method developed to manage uncertainty by considering a range of plausible futures rather than a single forecast ⁵³ ⁵⁴. Planners typically outline a **best case, a worst case, and one or more intermediate scenarios** for a given conflict ⁵³. This approach forces us to ask “what if” questions and identify the **turning points** that could lead to dramatically different outcomes ⁵⁵ ⁵⁶. It is important to emphasize that **scenarios are not predictions**; rather, they are **analytical tools** to anticipate how a war could evolve and to prepare appropriate responses ⁵⁷ ⁵⁸. In effect, scenario analysis acknowledges that we cannot perfectly predict the future, but we can map out several **alternative paths** the war might take and thus avoid being caught off-guard ⁵³ ⁵⁶. This section will neutrally outline multiple scenarios for “the war” and the early warning implications of each, drawing on expert assessments. (For concreteness, we consider the ongoing war in Ukraine as a case study, given its global significance, though the framework can apply to other conflicts.)

Scenario 1: Worst-Case Escalation – Widening into Regional or Global War. In the most dire scenario, a local war spirals into a much larger conflict. Analysts have warned that the war in Ukraine, if mismanaged, could **escalate into a direct confrontation between major powers** – essentially a “**hybrid World War III**” involving NATO and possibly other theaters ⁵⁹ ⁶⁰. This scenario might be triggered by an incident such as a military miscalculation (e.g. a stray missile hitting a NATO member), or a deliberate decision by Russia to expand the war beyond Ukraine. It could also be fueled by other states seizing the moment to pursue their own aggressive aims (for example, a confrontation in East Asia occurring concurrently, emboldened by the West’s distraction) ⁶¹ ⁶². The **early warning signs** of such an escalation would include things like: explicit threats of broader war (rhetoric about attacking NATO), mobilization of additional fronts or armies, or proliferation of conflict to new regions (for instance, unrest in the Balkans or Caucasus triggered by the Ukraine war). In this worst case, the risk of **nuclear weapons use** becomes a central concern. Experts assess that if NATO and Russia were drawn into direct war, the chain of escalation could lead to a nuclear exchange – an outcome with **catastrophic global consequences** ⁶³ ⁶⁴. A U.S.–Russia nuclear war, even if unintended, could cause unprecedented devastation (studies suggest even a “limited” regional nuclear war could kill billions through climate effects) ⁶⁵. While the probability of this extreme scenario is low, it is not zero; some strategic analyses have assigned a **non-negligible probability (e.g. ~20%)** to a scenario of global conflict emanating from the Ukraine war ⁶⁶ ⁶⁷. Because the stakes are existential, **even low-probability worst cases must be taken seriously** in scenario planning ⁵⁴. Early diplomatic and military signals must be closely watched to ensure any signs of horizontal escalation (spreading conflict) are addressed immediately. The international community’s **preventive priority in this scenario is**

absolute: everything must be done to contain the war and avoid crossing the threshold into world war or nuclear use.

Scenario 2: Protracted Stalemate – War of Attrition. A more middling scenario is that the war continues but remains contained geographically, turning into a **grinding war of attrition**. In this outcome, neither side achieves a decisive victory; instead, the conflict settles into a prolonged struggle with fluctuating intensity. This scenario may actually be the *most likely* in many expert assessments – for example, one report gave a protracted, lower-intensity attritional war the highest single probability (around 38%) among possible trajectories ⁶⁷. Early warning signs for a protracted conflict include patterns such as **repeated offensives that yield limited gains, continued mobilization of troops and supplies without peace talks making progress, and neither side exhibiting collapse**. Essentially, warning indicators here are the absence of resolution despite exhaustion: rising casualty counts, economic strain on the belligerents, but also ongoing external support (weapons, funds) enabling the war to drag on. In Ukraine, one sign of this path in 2023–2025 was that **both Russia and Ukraine dug in for a long fight**, entrenching positions and adapting strategy (e.g. drone warfare, defensive fortifications), indicating that a quick victory was out of reach. International early warning monitors in this scenario focus on **humanitarian indicators** (like civilian suffering, refugee flows) as well as **conflict intensity metrics** (frequency of clashes, territorial control changes) to gauge if the war might escalate or de-escalate. The critical risk in a stalemate scenario is that it can *suddenly explode* into a larger war if a new trigger arises – war fatigue or desperation might push one side into a risky escalation, or an external actor might directly intervene. Therefore, even a contained war of attrition needs active diplomatic management to prevent **“stable conflict” from becoming unstable**. On the positive side, a long stalemate can also increase pressure for negotiation as the costs mount, so early warning teams also watch for **openings to mediation** – such as backchannel talks, ceasefire pauses, or shifts in domestic public opinion against the war.

Scenario 3: Ceasefire or Fragile Peace Deal – Temporary Lull. In this scenario, active hostilities halt via a **ceasefire or preliminary peace agreement**, but the core issues remain unresolved. This outcome might come about due to war exhaustion, international pressure, or a stalemate prompting both sides to seek a break. However, analysts warn that **not all ceasefires lead to lasting peace**. A ceasefire could simply freeze the conflict lines, essentially pausing the war without addressing its causes. For example, imagine a negotiated truce in Ukraine that stops the fighting but does not settle questions of territory or security alignments. **Early warning analysis does not end** when a ceasefire is signed – instead, it shifts to monitoring the **durability** of the agreement. Warning signs in a post-ceasefire environment include: continued military build-up behind the lines (one side rearming under the guise of peace), frequent ceasefire violations or skirmishes, inflammatory propaganda that resumes, or lack of progress in follow-up negotiations. The **GLOBSEC 2025 report by security experts concluded that even an “acceptable” ceasefire scenario in Ukraine (one that addresses some of Ukraine’s interests) would likely be unstable and short-lived** ⁶⁸ ⁶⁹. They noted that Russia could use ambiguous treaty language and any pause in fighting to **regroup for a future attack**, while pressuring a war-weary West to reduce support to Ukraine ⁷⁰ ⁷¹. In other words, a premature peace can create a *“peace trap”* – a false sense of security that allows the aggressor to prepare the next round of conflict ⁷². Thus, early warning experts would keep a vigilant eye during a ceasefire for signs of either side violating terms or preparing for renewed warfare. Key indicators might be satellite imagery of troop movements (are heavy weapons being pulled back or quietly repositioned?), intelligence on ammunition production, or political signals like hardline rhetoric about “waiting for the right moment to finish the job.” A ceasefire scenario is certainly preferable to active war in humanitarian terms, but it must be buttressed by **robust monitoring and verification**. Peacekeepers or international observers can help provide early warnings of any breach. Ultimately, **transforming a fragile ceasefire into a durable peace would require tackling the root causes** – which might involve difficult concessions, justice/accountability measures,

and long-term security guarantees. Without that, early warning models would assess a high risk of relapse into conflict (a cycle of “war-ceasefire-war”).

Scenario 4: Best-Case Resolution – Comprehensive Peace Settlement. This scenario represents the **optimistic end-state**: a conflict is resolved through diplomacy, resulting in a settlement that addresses the main grievances and provides security guarantees for all sides. In the context of the war in question, a best-case could involve a negotiated agreement with robust international backing – for instance, withdrawal of invading forces, restoration of recognized borders or an agreed compromise, war reparations or reconstruction aid, and a framework that prevents future aggression (such as neutral status for a contested region with UN peacekeepers, or security assurances by major powers). In 2014, at the outset of the Ukraine crisis, one analyst imagined the best case as the crisis being “resolved diplomatically through increased Russia–Europe cooperation, which would be a big step toward world peace” ⁷³ ⁶³ . Such a scenario would likely require extraordinary political will and perhaps changes in leadership or regime incentives. The **early warning signs** that a best-case peace is coming into view might include: genuine concessions in negotiations, conciliatory statements in public (e.g. acknowledgement of the other side’s core demands), war fatigue in domestic politics strong enough to mandate compromise, and active engagement by neutral mediators or powerful third parties pushing for a deal. We must candidly note that **this scenario is the hardest to achieve** – in many conflict analyses, a truly stable and just peace agreement is given a low probability (in the Ukraine expert scenario mentioned, a fully satisfactory peace for Ukraine was deemed only ~2% likely ⁷⁴ ⁶⁸). The obstacles are immense, especially if at least one warring party still harbors maximalist aims (for example, if an aggressor fundamentally does not accept the sovereignty or existence of the other, as was cited regarding Russia’s stance toward Ukraine’s independence ⁷⁵). Nonetheless, this scenario is the one the international community strives for. **Preventive diplomacy and peacebuilding efforts are geared to increase the chance of this best case** over time. Early warning in this context is about seizing opportunities: identifying moments of leverage (e.g. economic collapse forcing a party to negotiate, or a leadership change opening new dialogue) and reinforcing any positive trends (such as local ceasefires or prisoner exchanges that build trust). In a best-case trajectory, early warning analysts effectively become **early opportunity analysts**, flagging when conditions might be ripe for a breakthrough in peace negotiations. The world has seen conflicts end against the odds – for instance, the Cold War concluded peacefully, and long wars in places like Angola or Colombia eventually found settlements. These successes often had early diplomatic feelers and confidence-building steps that were noticed and nurtured by the UN or regional actors. Therefore, even if unlikely, the best-case path must always be kept in view and actively promoted.

Summary of Scenarios: The war’s future might follow any of these paths – or a combination, sequentially (e.g. a stalemate leading to a ceasefire, which then collapses into renewed war). Scenario analysis underscores that **we must prepare for multiple outcomes simultaneously** ⁵⁴ ⁵⁶ . An important insight from this exercise is that **no scenario is predetermined**. Human choices – diplomatic, military, economic – will influence which path materializes. Early warning plays a role not just in predicting the next moves, but in shaping them: by warning of the worst case, actors can be spurred to take preventive action; by illustrating a best case, actors can be inspired to strive for peace. For instance, knowing the worst-case could be a global war, leaders might act more cautiously or re-engage in dialogue (as arguably happened during the Cuban Missile Crisis when warnings of nuclear winter sobered the superpowers). Conversely, recognizing that a ceasefire alone could be a trap ⁷² might push negotiators to aim for a more comprehensive solution rather than a quick fix. In short, scenario planning is a critical companion to early warning: it helps **connect the dots from warning signs to potential futures** ³⁰ , ensuring that policymakers are not blindsided by how fast things can change. As one methodology guide put it, scenarios expand our thinking by showing “how and why things could quite quickly become much better or worse in new and unexpected ways,” thus counteracting biases and improving readiness ⁵⁵ ⁷⁶ .

Conclusion

The outbreak of war is often portrayed as a sudden catastrophe, but in reality it is almost always preceded by **early warning signs** that, if recognized and acted upon, could mitigate or even prevent the worst outcomes. In this report, we have surveyed the full spectrum of those signs – from deep structural drivers like grievances and arms buildups, to immediate triggers like troop movements and political assassinations. We have also examined the **intricate challenges** in translating warnings into preventive action, highlighting why neutrality, accuracy, and evidence are paramount: misinformation or bias can lead to miscalculations in these fraught situations, which is why rigorous analysis under “red team” scrutiny is essential for truth-telling in conflict early warnings. Finally, we explored multiple scenarios for how a war can evolve, illustrating that the future is not fixed; wise policy and timely intervention can avert the worst-case and inch us closer to the best-case. Each scenario carries its own warning indicators and decision points.

For the international community – the UN, regional organizations, governments, and civil society – the task ahead is to **strengthen an integrated early warning-and-action system**. This means investing in better data and analytical tools (including emerging AI capabilities) **to catch warning signs early** ³¹ ²⁶, but equally improving the political and diplomatic mechanisms that can respond to those warnings. The cost of failure is evident in history’s regrets: many wars could have been limited or averted if only warnings had been taken seriously. The **cost of success**, on the other hand, is measured in crises *not* occurring – a peace maintained, a massacre avoided, a war that stays cold. As conflicts continue in various parts of the world (with violence reaching “a new normal” of elevated levels in recent years ⁷⁷ ⁷⁸), there is great urgency to close the warning-response gap.

In sum, early warning is our early chance to safeguard peace. It provides the flashing signals on the dashboard of international security, but it is up to human agents to hit the brakes or steer in a safer direction. By remaining vigilant, neutral, and guided by facts – and by planning for multiple contingencies – we improve our odds of preventing the next war or bringing ongoing ones to a just end. In a world armed with information, **surprise wars should become a thing of the past**. The world is indeed watching, and with collective commitment, we can ensure that when warning bells ring, they spur action that keeps the **fires of conflict** from raging out of control ⁷⁹ ⁸⁰.

Sources: The analysis above is based on a synthesis of expert research and reports on conflict early warning and war scenarios, including publications by conflict researchers ⁴⁸ ⁸¹, security think-tanks ⁶⁰ ⁶⁷, data from international monitoring organizations ⁸² ⁸³, and news agencies’ accounts of specific warning signs in recent conflicts ²⁰ ⁴⁵. All evidence has been cited in-text to maintain transparency and neutrality.

¹ ² ³ ³¹ ³² ³³ ³⁴ ³⁵ ³⁶ ³⁷ ³⁸ ³⁹ ⁴¹ ⁴² ⁵¹ ⁵² **Warning Without Response: Why Early Warning Fails, and How to Turn Foresight Into Prevention**

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